



2018 MERCEDES-BENZ S350D TECHNOLOGY, DRIVE REVIEW: ENTER, ROYALTY

There is something about the 'best car in the world' that will make you fall in love with it, even with all the competition around.

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BUILD QUALITY, DESIGN AND AESTHETICS

The W222 Mercedes-Benz S350d is 5.25 metres long, with a wheelbase of 3,165 mm. The side profile is smooth, long and swooping, with an immaculately finished chassis ending in a rear profile that is swept back.

Inside, the silk beige/espresso brown genuine leather upholstery interspersed with brown open-pore ash wood looks magnificent.

The Mercedes-Benz S350d has soft-closing doors. Up front, two 12.3-inch displays are placed in one panel of glass. These are the infotainment display and the instrument cluster. There are two 10.1-inch displays for the rear seat.

The hydraulic chrome push knobs, slide-out ashtray and AC vents all have a perfection of finish. Even the cup holders have adjustable side bolsters, to prevent spillage. The control area has a

host of buttons, along with a click wheel and a touchpad. You get two more touchpads mounted on the steering wheel, making operation quite easy.

Other clever bits include dual-side-opening central armrest, NFC connectivity and more. The seats get the expected ventilation and massager. The fantastic Burmester speaker setup is quite impressive, but the more impressive bits are the full-recline rear seat, and the 64-colour ambient LEDs.

SEMI-AUTONOMOUS DRIVER ASSIST SYSTEMS

The Mercedes-Benz S350d has one of the most complete ADAS packages, including front and rear radars, infrared and proximity sensors and multiple cameras. The features include 360-degree camera with autonomous parking, active brake

assist with manually adjustable proximity distance, interior sensor-based driver attention and distraction assist, active lane-keeping assistance, blind spot monitoring, cross-traffic alert, pedestrian and obstacle assistance, adaptive cruise control, collision mitigation system, auto-adaptive Highbeam Assist Plus headlamps, automatic bending and cornering lights, and adaptive 'Airmatic' air suspension.

However, do make sure that you switch active braking off because of the lack of road rules in India, and raise the suspension when you're in city.

INFOTAINMENT, CONNECTIVITY AND ELECTRONICS

You get Apple CarPlay and Android Auto as well, and programmable sections too. Wi-Fi connectivity is available, along with smartphone sync and app support, which can help you load supported apps to the system via your phone's Bluetooth. You can also get live traffic updates, email prompts and other notifications through this.

There's a forcemeter, which shows engine power delivery and torque when in dynamic mode. The ambient LEDs, along with features like the Multibeam

LED headlamps, air focus and air fragrance dissipator, dedicated infotainment remotes and more make it a truly special car here.

- **Price:** ₹1.32 crore;
- **Powertrain:** 2.9-litre in-line six-cylinder diesel, 286bhp/600Nm, 9-speed 9G-TRONIC automatic gearbox, 4MATIC permanent all-wheel drive;
- **Fuel economy:** 9.1kmpl (obtained);
- **Pros:** Regal stance, Immense road presence, Impeccable build quality, Dozes class and luxury, Semi-autonomous technology is extremely solid, Infotainment is future-ready, Burmester 13-speaker setup sounds excellent, Unmatched rear seat luxury, Solid engine and brilliant gearbox, Air suspension wafts over everything, Has pretty much everything you can hope for in a car;
- **Cons:** No massager in front seats, Proprietary headphones could have been better, No magic sky control here, No automatic boot, Adaptive braking is a bit too sharp;

THE ROYAL DRIVE

Despite the weight, length and bulk, the S350d hits 100kph in 6.0 seconds, and can technically go all the way up to 250kmph. The power delivery is linear, and not for once do you feel out of power. It is not a particularly exciting engine per se, but the focus here is on luxury. Hence, you get the magical air suspension, which is absolutely brilliant. **[I]**